



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-123
FIRST IN COUNCIL
June 8, 2026

COUNCILLOR FLAHERTY
COUNCILLOR ZUSY

- WHEREAS: On February 10, 2025, the Cambridge City Council voted to adopt a zoning petition to allow multifamily housing citywide; and
- WHEREAS: The zoning changes were intended to enable multifamily housing across all Cambridge neighborhoods, increase overall housing production, prioritize income-restricted affordable units through the City’s Inclusionary Housing Program, and eliminate certain requirements such as minimum lot sizes, limits on the number of dwelling units, and restrictions on floor area; and
- WHEREAS: The zoning code amendments established a unified residential zoning district, “Residence C-1,” applicable across all neighborhoods, allowing buildings up to four stories in height, or up to six stories for projects that meet inclusionary housing requirements (20% affordable) and are located on lots of at least 5,000 square feet; and
- WHEREAS: The amendments eliminated minimum lot size requirements, limits on dwelling units, and the total allowable floor area for housing; and
- WHEREAS: The amendments also reduced setback requirements and imposed new open space and Green Factor standards for new buildings; and
- WHEREAS: The adoption and implementation of the multifamily zoning ordinance have led to significant unintended consequences across all neighborhoods, as real estate development activity has increasingly focused on maximizing profits while avoiding the provision of income-restricted affordable housing; and
- WHEREAS: The Cambridge Community Development Department has undertaken extensive and detailed analysis to develop proposed amendments to the multifamily zoning ordinance aimed at addressing unintended consequences while advancing the goal of increasing housing production, particularly income-restricted affordable housing; and
- WHEREAS: Residents across all Cambridge neighborhoods have expressed widespread concern and dissatisfaction regarding the unintended consequences of the multifamily zoning ordinance; now therefore be it
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to direct the Community Development Department, and other relevant City departments, to examine and report back to the City Council with a feasibility analysis with findings, options, and recommendations regarding the following proposed amendments to the multifamily

zoning ordinance;

1. Require front, side, and rear setbacks totaling at least 35 feet, with at least one side setback of no less than 10 feet;
2. Explore possibility of relating building height to width of right of way; 6 story buildings only on major thoroughfares, not on narrow residential streets. Consider right of way widths of 55' and greater;
3. 30% open space should be green open space at grade. Green roofs and balconies should not qualify as part of green open space, nor should permeable pavers;
4. Max building wall length 25-40 long side setback line (length to be studied). Building wall longer than 25-40' to set back an additional 5' to allow for privacy, light, new plantings, etc.;
5. Require one off-street automobile parking space for each dwelling unit above four units in any new construction, whether in Residence C-1 or otherwise.

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council within 60 days with a feasibility analysis, including findings and options regarding the above-referenced items.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-



Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to direct the Community Development Department, and other relevant City departments, to examine and report back to the City Council with a feasibility analysis with findings, options, and recommendations regarding the following proposed amendments to the multifamily zoning ordinance.